

Darius' army: The Persians

The infantry

The Persians

The infantry used the bow as a major weapon, and carried spears about 1.8 metres long. The Royal Guard, or Immortals, carried shields, similar to the Greek hoplon, for protection and wore leather cuirasses similar to those worn by the Macedonians. Reliefs from the Apadana at Persepolis and the description of these troops in Book 7 of Herodotus' *Histories* give evidence of this. The ordinary Persian infantrymen were called *kardakes*. They carried wicker shields and wore lighter armour than the Immortals.

Other infantry

As well as the Persian troops the army quite often contained large numbers of subject troops of poor quality. According to Arrian (3.11) Darius made use of Medes, Hycarnians, Assyrians and many more from different satrapies across the empire. These used the weapons and armour traditional to their homelands. Darius also relied upon mercenaries, many of whom were Greeks and fought as hoplites. These were supposedly the only infantry capable of being a match for the Macedonians.

The cavalry

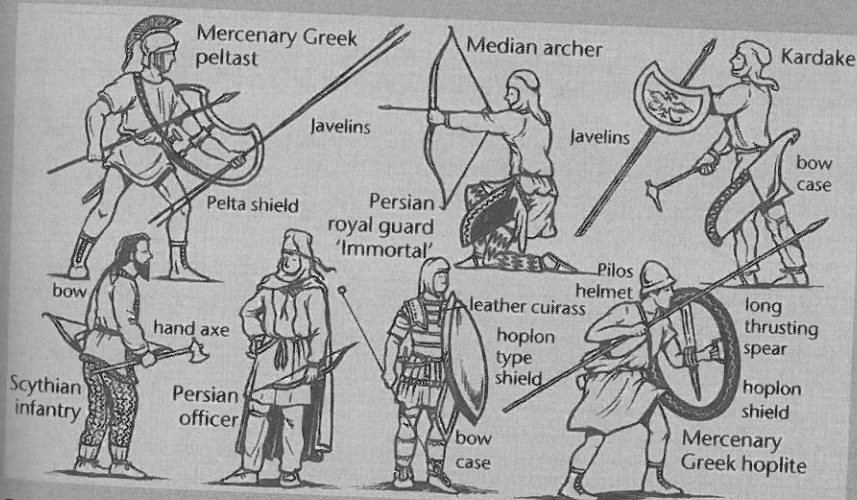
The Persians relied on cavalry more than the Greeks and Macedonians. They were usually armed with bows and or some sort of short spears or javelins designed to be used as a throwing weapon or to thrust at an opponent from a close range. These would have been no more than 1.8 metres long.

The Persians

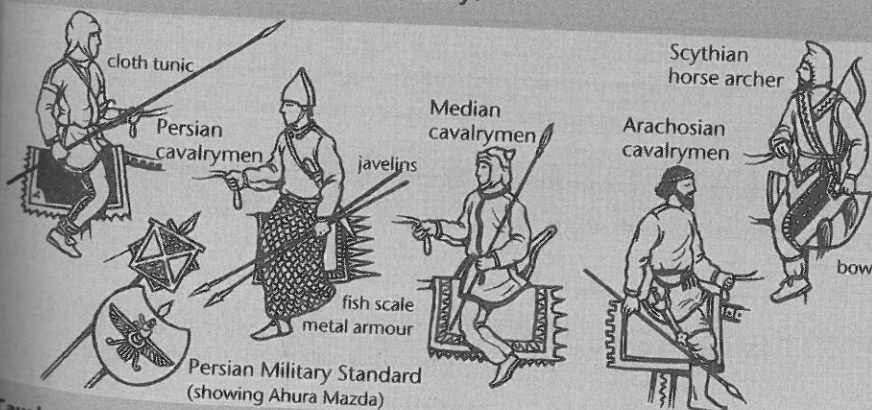
The best cavalry in the Persian army were the Persians themselves. These troops came from the noble families of Persia. Each cavalryman wore armour that he provided himself. Most wore some type of metal helmet covered by a cloth cap to protect the wearer from overheating. Most of these troops also wore metal-scale cuirasses covered by elaborately decorated robes.

Other cavalry

Other cavalry used in the Persian army were the Medes, Sakae, Dahae, Bactrians and Arachosians. Most of these wore very little body armour and used javelins or bows as their main weapons. The majority of them were used as skirmishing troops.



Persian infantry types. Compare these illustrations with those of Alexander's army on p142. How does the armour and weaponry of the Persian infantry differ from that of the Macedonian infantry?



Cavalry types used in the Persian army. Compare these illustrations with those of Alexander's cavalry on p143. What advantage would the Macedonian cavalry have over the Persian cavalry in hand-to-hand combat?

